who has been inside the team for 14 years. Of course, these are *my* opinions and they are therefore subjective, but they certainly represent a viewpoint shared by quite a few of my teammates over the years. And I say this while acknowledging all my own failings and shortcomings as a player, when the team could've done with more consistent performances from yours truly. Here we go, then …

I believe that the main factor that has contributed to the Proteas' underachievement is an overly conservative approach to the game.

Putting the 'conservative' back into cricket

I touched on the Proteas' lack of big-match temperament in Chapter 3, but it's a subject that definitely deserves a bit more attention. The press and our opponents love to call us chokers, but I think that's far too simplistic an analysis. Yes, I agree that we don't always have the *kop* for the big occasion, but it's important to understand why that is the case. I believe it comes down to an ingrained fear of failure, reinforced by a fundamentally conservative strategy – particularly in 20- and 50-over cricket.

The fear of failure is our Achilles heel. This fear has overcome us time and time again in big tournaments. Perhaps it stems from that awful semi-final loss against the Aussies in the 1999 World Cup. Maybe those scars run so deep that their memory still hampers any chances we may have of winning when the chips are down. Whatever the reason, we always seem to get paralysed by the occasion. We're so petrified of losing that we tighten up. You never see that happen with teams such as India, Sri Lanka and, obviously, Australia. But we do it, as do England, and the West Indies too – basically the teams that don't consistently perform in limited-overs cricket are always too tentative. I mean, it's not like we don't have enough talented players. Shit … we had enough players to help England win the 2010 T20 World Cup.

Having mentioned it, the recent T20 World Cup in the West Indies illustrates my point perfectly. Prior to the tournament's kick-off, we had a big team meeting aboard a cruise ship in the Caribbean. The aim was to clear the air and for everyone to give their 10 cents' worth. Everyone was supposed to be really honest about what it would take for us to be successful in the tournament.

I made the point that the big tournaments are the ultimate opportunity for us to show the world how good we are at limited-overs cricket, both as